

Gauntlet v0.6 Mystics Faction Guide

Definitive v0.6 Mystics faction source. This guide governs all Mystics-specific rules, leaders, Rites, Ritual victory, Invocation, Transmutation, bound cards, supplemental components, strategy, terminology, and the canonical twelve-card pool. The adjacent DOCX and PDF are release-formatted editions of this source. General game rules remain in the v0.6 core rules.

Use this guide with the Gauntlet v0.6 core rules. General movement, battle, withdrawal, occupation, capture, deck construction, Assets, Overlays, card destinations, and ordinary breakthrough victory procedures remain in the core rulebook.

Leader illustrations for release layout use:

/tmp/mystics-release/alchemist_portrait.jpg

/tmp/mystics-release/spirit_walker_portrait.jpg

The printable Leader Cards use the corresponding portraits under ../../../../images/.

1. Mystics overview

The Mystics treat the Graveyard as a place of transformation rather than simple loss. They sacrifice cards, recover selected value, alter normal timing and card access, and pursue three public Rites while continuing to contest the Gauntlet.

Faction identity: Change what a card is worth by changing where it is, when it is spent, and whether it is truly gone.

Victory: normal breakthrough victory or Ritual victory.

Ritual victory: complete all three Rites.

Trait: all twelve Mystics cards have the **Arcane** trait.

Shared progression: the first completed Rite unlocks **Invocation**; the second unlocks **Transmutation**; the third immediately wins by Ritual.

Leaders: Alchemist or Spirit Walker.

Faction pool: 12 unique cards; curve 1 / 3 / 4 / 3 / 1 at costs 1-5.

Cost-5 statement: Necromancy.

Components and setup

A Mystics deck uses:

one selected Leader Card: **Alchemist** or **Spirit Walker**;

one **Mystics Reference** summarizing Ritual, Invocation, Transmutation, and bound cards;

three double-sided Rite cards: **Rite of Echoes**, **Rite of Blood**, and **Rite of Crossing**;

any Mystics playable cards included through normal deck construction.

At setup, place the three Rite cards incomplete side up and place the Mystics Reference nearby. A completed Rite is flipped to its completed side. Completed Rites remain public and cannot be begun again. No token or resource tracker is required.

2. Ritual, Rites, Invocation, and Transmutation

Ritual structure

During the Action phase after movement, instead of playing an Action card, you may begin one incomplete Rite by paying its beginning cost.

You may have only one begun but incomplete Rite at a time.

You may begin any uncompleted Rite; the Rites have no required order.

A Rite cannot be completed on the turn it begins.

Only one Rite may be completed per turn.

If a Rite is interrupted, it resets and paid costs are not returned unless that Rite says otherwise.

When you complete your first Rite, unlock **Invocation**.

When you complete your second Rite, unlock **Transmutation**.

When you complete your third Rite, immediately win by **Ritual**.

Completing Rites does not prevent ordinary movement, battle, occupation, capture, or breakthrough victory. A player may shift between Ritual pressure and conventional territorial play as the game changes.

Bound cards

Cards bound to a Rite or another card are outside every normal zone.

A face-up bound card is public information.

A face-down bound card may be viewed by its owner but not by the opponent.

A bound card cannot be played, moved, or affected except as instructed by the effect to which it is bound.

If an effect ends while a card remains bound to it, follow that effect's destination instruction. If none is given, place the bound card in its owner's Graveyard.

Invocation

Invocation: Once per turn, when you play an Arcane card, you may move one card from your Graveyard to your discard pile.

Invocation is optional. It triggers from playing an Arcane card regardless of whether that card came from hand, battle draw, the Graveyard, or another effect, unless a rule says the card was not played.

Invocation returns a chosen card to the normal deck cycle but does not put it directly into hand. Leaving a useful card in the Graveyard may be preferable when preparing Soul for Soul, Rend the Veil, Necromancy, or Rite of Echoes.

Transmutation

Transmutation: Once per turn, before dice are rolled in a battle involving you, you may send one card from your hand to your Graveyard. Add its deckbuilding value to your battle total.

This is neither a hand commitment nor a battle-drawn play. The card has no Action or Battle effect when used this way. Supplemental cards cannot be used.

Transmutation converts future card value into immediate battle strength. High-cost cards provide more power, but may also be the cards the player most wants to preserve, retrieve, or use later.

3. The three Rites

Rite of Echoes

Beginning cost: Bind one chosen card from your Graveyard face up beneath this Rite. Then bind one card from your hand face down beneath this Rite whose title matches at least one other card in your constructed deck.

Completion: On a later turn, complete this Rite when you play another card with the bound hand card's title during battle.

On completion:

move the selected Graveyard card to your discard pile;

place the bound hand card in your Graveyard;

the completing card resolves normally and follows its normal destination;

flip Rite of Echoes to its completed side.

If you lose a battle before completing this Rite, place both bound cards in your Graveyard and reset the Rite.

Rite of Echoes rewards duplicate titles and deliberate Graveyard preparation without requiring any particular faction card. The selected Graveyard card need not share the duplicated title.

Rite of Blood

Beginning cost: Send one card from your hand to your Graveyard.

Completion: On a later turn, complete this Rite when you win a battle without committing a card from hand and without playing a battle-drawn card.

Using Transmutation, an Asset, an Overlay, a Territory effect, a leader ability, or a card played from the Graveyard does not by itself prevent completion. If you lose a battle before completing this Rite, reset the Rite.

When completed, flip Rite of Blood to its completed side.

Rite of Blood asks the player to win through preparation, positioning, dice manipulation, or resources outside the two normal Battle-card sources.

Rite of Crossing

You may begin this Rite only after you win a battle that causes you to occupy a Territory the opponent controlled immediately before that battle.

Beginning cost: Send one Arcane card from your hand to your Graveyard. If you have no Arcane card in hand, reveal your hand and send one Arcane card from your discard pile to your Graveyard instead.

Completion: At the beginning of your next turn, after captures, complete this Rite if you still occupy or control that Territory. Otherwise, the Rite is interrupted and resets.

Heartlands do not count. When completed, flip Rite of Crossing to its completed side.

Rite of Crossing ties Ritual progress directly to the ordinary occupation and counterattack structure of the Gauntlet.

4. Mystics leaders

Alchemist



Nothing is fixed. Everything can be transformed.

Style: sacrifice sequencing, card conversion, disciplined occult experimentation.

The Alchemist treats every card sent from hand to the Graveyard as material for another experiment. He rewards careful sequencing: the first sacrifice on the player's turn can replace itself, but later sacrifices still carry their full cost.

Choose the Alchemist when you want to convert cards aggressively, combine Transmutation with Arcane abilities, and decide which sacrifice deserves the turn's replacement draw.

Materia Prima

The first time on your turn that you send a card from your hand to your Graveyard as part of a Rite, Transmutation, or an Arcane card ability, draw one card. If this happens during battle, draw after the battle resolves.

Materia Prima triggers only on your own turn and only from the listed Mystic or Arcane sources. An ordinary hand commitment does not trigger it merely because that card later enters the Graveyard during cleanup.

Alchemist priorities:

- decide which sacrifice should receive the Materia Prima draw;
- use low-value or poorly timed cards as material without treating every Graveyard entry as free;
- preserve high-value cards when Necromancy, Soul for Soul, or Transmutation may make them more valuable later;
- avoid exhausting the hand so aggressively that Rites and battles become impossible to support.

Spirit Walker



The spirits remember what the living abandon.

Style: ritual endurance, protective sacrifice, Graveyard communion.

The Spirit Walker preserves begun Rites through sacrifice. Arcane cards in hand are therefore both playable effects and protective resources, creating tension between present power and the survival of public Ritual progress.

Choose the Spirit Walker when you want to attempt exposed Rites under pressure, reserve Arcane cards as protection, and force the opponent to win through more than one interruption attempt.

Guardians of the Circle

The first time on your turn that you lose a battle and a begun Rite would be interrupted, you may send one Arcane card from your hand to your Graveyard. If you do, that Rite is not interrupted.

Guardians of the Circle cannot prevent an interruption caused by failing an occupation or control requirement. In particular, it cannot complete or preserve Rite of Crossing when the required Territory is no longer occupied or controlled.

Spirit Walker priorities:

keep at least one Arcane card available when a critical Rite is exposed;

decide whether an Arcane card is more valuable as protection, a Battle effect, Invocation fuel, or Transmutation power;

use Graveyard recovery to rebuild protection without turning the hand into a passive reserve;

remember that the opponent can pressure both the Rite and the cards needed to preserve it.

5. Playing Mystics

The central Mystics decision is **what should be lost now, what should remain dead, and what should return.**

A well-played Mystics deck does not simply recover every card from its Graveyard. It chooses which cards should circulate through discard, which should remain available to Graveyard effects, which should be exchanged into hand, and which should be spent permanently for a decisive battle or Rite.

Strengths

multiple distinct ways to use, exchange, play, or recycle cards from the Graveyard;
flexible conversion of hand cards into movement, rerolls, copied effects, or battle strength;
public Ritual pressure that can force the opponent to contest specific timing windows;
unusual access to Battle effects through Witchcraft, Black Covenant, and Rend the Veil;
persistent Territory-altering Overlays that make chosen battlefields strategically different;
the ability to pivot between Ritual victory and ordinary breakthrough.

Limits

The Mystics have:

significant self-inflicted hand depletion;
visible and interruptible Ritual preparation;
no routine unconditional capture acceleration;
limited direct removal of opposing Assets, cards, or Overlays;
reliance on a useful Graveyard state for their highest ceilings;
vulnerability to effects that permanently suppress, relocate, or exploit Graveyard cards;
a particularly exposed relationship with the Inquisition, which profits when Arcane cards are played.

Strategic threads

Graveyard curation and recurrence: Grave Ward; Spirit Hollow; Soul for Soul; Rend the Veil; Necromancy; Invocation; Rite of Echoes

Sacrifice and transformation: Dark Omens; Fate's Toll; Witchcraft; Circle of Bones; Necromancy; Transmutation; Materia Prima

Altered timing and abnormal play: Witchcraft; Rend the Veil; Black Covenant; Paths of Shadow

Haunted ground and positional control: Spirit Hollow; Circle of Bones; Fate's Toll; Paths of Shadow

Ritual preparation and protection: Dark Omens; Black Covenant; Rend the Veil; Grave Ward; Guardians of the Circle

Conventional breakthrough support: Fate's Toll; Accursed Wager; Paths of Shadow; Circle of Bones; Transmutation

The pool is a strategic vocabulary, not a required recursion package. Invocation and the Rites function without any particular faction card. A deck may emphasize Graveyard access, sacrifice conversion, persistent cursed ground, battle combinations, Ritual completion, or a hybrid of several threads.

Playing against Mystics

pressure the Mystics player's hand after they pay sacrifice costs;
contest a begun Rite before Graveyard recovery and leader protection are prepared;
track which cards remain in the Graveyard and which have returned to discard;
remove or cover Spirit Hollow and Circle of Bones when their locations favor the Mystics player;

respect visible Assets such as Grave Ward, Rend the Veil, Witchcraft, and Black Covenant;
 force the Mystics player to spend Arcane cards now rather than preserve them for Spirit Walker protection;
 do not assume a card in the Graveyard is permanently unavailable.

6. Mystics-specific rules reference

Arcane trait and allegiance

The **Arcane** trait is separate from faction allegiance. All twelve Mystics cards are Arcane, but Neutral and opposing-faction cards may also have the trait. Playing an Arcane card may trigger Invocation, Blasphemy, or another effect that references the trait.

Card enters the Graveyard

A card enters the Graveyard before an effect such as Grave Ward moves it elsewhere. Entry triggers resolve from that entry even when the card is immediately moved to discard afterward.

Exchange

To exchange two cards, move each card simultaneously to the other card's previous zone. Both cards must still be eligible and present when the exchange resolves. If either card cannot move, the exchange does not occur.

Additional Battle cards

A card played from the Graveyard by Rend the Veil is an active Battle card, but is neither a hand commitment nor a battle-drawn play. It may be negated or affected normally. Its printed Battle effect resolves, and its destination is replaced by Rend the Veil's instruction.

A Battle card committed through Black Covenant is an additional hand commitment. It counts as committed from hand and follows the normal destination for a hand commitment.

Effects that resolve or repeat Battle effects

An effect that resolves or repeats another card's Battle effect cannot choose an effect that would play another Battle card or resolve or repeat another Battle effect, unless it explicitly permits one additional layer. An additional layer cannot create another layer.

When a Battle effect resolves an additional time:

- make all choices again;
- pay all costs again;
- apply source-dependent instructions only when they can legally function;
- apply instructions that change the source card's destination or status only once.

An impossible instruction does not prevent the rest of an otherwise legal effect from resolving unless that instruction is a required cost or target.

Eligible Battle effect

For Witchcraft, an **eligible Battle effect**:

- belongs to another active Battle card you played;
- can legally resolve in the current battle;
- does not play another Battle card;
- does not resolve or repeat another Battle effect.

Witchcraft cannot repeat Arcane Knowledge, Black Covenant, Rend the Veil, Heresy, Treason, another Witchcraft, or any other effect whose function is to play or resolve an additional Battle card or Battle effect.

Overlay ownership and choices

Unless an Overlay says otherwise, its owner makes all choices for its effect. Changing control of the Territory does not transfer ownership of the Overlay.

A printed condition that removes an Overlay remains active while that Overlay is dormant beneath another Overlay. Spirit Hollow and Circle of Bones therefore leave play when their Territory is captured even while covered.

After battle cleanup

An effect that occurs **after battle cleanup** resolves after all ordinary played-card destinations and other cleanup instructions. Cards newly placed in the Graveyard during that cleanup are eligible for Spirit Hollow.

Bottom of the draw pile

When Necromancy is placed beneath the draw pile, it is placed face down as the bottom card. Its owner and opponent know its location from the public effect, but it is not in hand, discard, or Graveyard and cannot be affected as a card in any of those zones.

7. Canonical Mystics card pool

Dark Omens

Cost: 1

Complexity: Basic

Trait: Arcane

Action: Draw two cards, then place one of them in your Graveyard.

Battle: Draw one card. You may place it in your Graveyard. If you do, gain advantage.

Accursed Wager

Cost: 2

Complexity: Basic

Trait: Arcane

Action: After the next battle you initiate this turn, the loser places one card from their hand in their Graveyard, if able.

Battle: After this battle, the loser places one card from their hand in their Graveyard, if able.

Fate's Toll

Cost: 2

Complexity: Basic

Trait: Arcane

Action: Place one other card from your hand in your Graveyard. Gain one additional movement this turn.

Battle: After you roll, you may place one other card from your hand in your Graveyard to reroll. You must use the new result.

Grave Ward

Cost: 2

Complexity: Advanced

Trait: Arcane

Action: Bank Grave Ward as an Asset. When a card enters your Graveyard, you may discard Grave Ward. If you do, move that card from your Graveyard to your discard pile.

Battle: During battle cleanup, choose one other card you committed from your hand this battle. Move it from your Graveyard to your discard pile.

Spirit Hollow

Cost: 3

Complexity: Advanced

Trait: Arcane

Card form: Overlay

Action: Place this card face up on your current Territory or an adjacent revealed Territory. It becomes an Overlay.

Battle: Place this card face up on the contested Territory. It becomes an Overlay instead of entering its normal destination.

Overlay: After battle cleanup following a battle here, each player may place one card from their hand in their Graveyard. A player who does may move one other card from their Graveyard to their discard pile.

When this Territory is captured, place this card in its owner's Graveyard.

Soul for Soul

Cost: 3

Complexity: Advanced

Trait: Arcane

Action: Choose one card in your hand and one card in your Graveyard. Exchange them.

Battle: During battle cleanup, after cards committed from your hand enter your Graveyard, you may exchange one card in your hand with one other card in your Graveyard that you committed from hand in this battle.

Rend the Veil

Cost: 3

Complexity: Advanced

Trait: Arcane

Action: Bank this card as an Asset. After Battle cards are revealed in a battle involving you, you may discard this card. If you do, choose one card in your Graveyard whose Battle effect can resolve in this battle and does not play another Battle card or resolve or repeat another Battle effect. Play the chosen card as an additional Battle card.

Battle: When revealed, you may choose one card in your Graveyard whose Battle effect can resolve in this battle and does not play another Battle card or resolve or repeat another Battle effect. Play the chosen card as an additional Battle card.

Reminder: A card played this way is neither a hand commitment nor a battle-drawn play. During battle cleanup, move it to your discard pile instead of any other destination.

Paths of Shadow

Cost: 3

Complexity: Advanced

Trait: Arcane

Action: Move to any revealed Territory you control. This movement cannot initiate a battle.

Battle: If you lose this battle, you may move to any revealed Territory you control instead of withdrawing normally.

Witchcraft

Cost: 4

Complexity: Advanced

Trait: Arcane

Action: Bank this card as an Asset. Once per turn, after Battle cards are revealed in a battle involving you, you may place one card from your hand in your Graveyard. If you do, choose one other active Battle card you played with an eligible Battle effect. That effect resolves one additional time during this battle.

Battle: When revealed, choose one other active Battle card you played with an eligible Battle effect. That effect resolves one additional time during this battle. If you cannot choose one, gain advantage. During battle cleanup, place this card in your Graveyard.

Reminder: An eligible Battle effect can legally resolve in this battle and does not play another Battle card or resolve or repeat another Battle effect. Make all choices and pay all costs again when it repeats.

Black Covenant

Cost: 4

Complexity: Advanced

Trait: Arcane

Action: Bind one other card from your hand face down beneath this card, then bank this card as an Asset. While banked, you may play the bound card as an Action or commit it during a battle at a legal time as though it were in your hand. This is an additional Action-card play or hand commitment. The bound card follows the normal destination for a card played or committed from hand. After the bound card resolves, place this card in your Graveyard.

Battle: When revealed, you may bind one other Battle card from your hand beneath this card, then immediately commit and reveal it as an additional hand commitment. During battle cleanup, place this card in your Graveyard.

Reminder: If this card leaves play while a card remains bound beneath it, place the bound card in your Graveyard.

Circle of Bones

Cost: 4

Complexity: Advanced

Trait: Arcane

Card form: Overlay

Action: Place this card face up on your current Territory or an adjacent revealed Territory. It becomes an Overlay.

Battle: Place this card face up on the contested Territory. It becomes an Overlay instead of entering its normal destination.

Overlay: Once during each battle here involving you, after dice are rolled, you may place one card from your hand in your Graveyard. If you do, choose either player. That player rerolls and must use the new result.

When this Territory is captured, place this card in its owner's Graveyard.

Necromancy

Cost: 5

Complexity: Advanced

Trait: Arcane

Unique: Maximum one copy per deck

Action: Choose one:

Place this card face down beneath your draw pile, then draw one card.

Choose up to three non-Necromancy cards in your Graveyard. Place every other card in your hand in your Graveyard, then return the chosen cards to your hand. Place this card in your Graveyard.

Battle: During battle cleanup, after your other played cards follow their normal destinations, choose up to three non-Necromancy cards in your Graveyard. Place every card remaining in your hand in your Graveyard, then return the chosen cards to your hand. This card follows its normal destination.

8. Package summary and development watchlist

Cost profile

1: Dark Omens

2: Accursed Wager; Fate's Toll; Grave Ward

3: Spirit Hollow; Soul for Soul; Rend the Veil; Paths of Shadow

4: Witchcraft; Black Covenant; Circle of Bones

5: Necromancy

Total: 12 cards

Total unique-card value: 36

Average cost: 3.00

Curve: 1 / 3 / 4 / 3 / 1 at costs 1-5

Unique card: Necromancy

Arcane cards: all twelve

Initial playtest watchlist

whether Necromancy can be recovered and reused too easily, especially through Rend the Veil, Soul for Soul, Grave Ward, Spirit Hollow, or Invocation;

whether Alchemist plus Grave Ward preserves sacrifice value too efficiently;

whether Materia Prima makes Fate's Toll or Circle of Bones underpriced;

whether Black Covenant's additional Action and hand-commitment sequencing is clear and balanced;

whether Rend the Veil at cost 3 outperforms Neutral Arcane Knowledge at cost 4;

whether Witchcraft's copied-effect ceiling remains interactive and understandable;

whether Spirit Hollow and Circle of Bones create compelling contested locations without excessive tracking;

whether all-twelve Arcane trait assignment makes Blasphemy an oppressive counter rather than healthy matchup pressure;

whether the three Rites are comparably achievable and create visible interruption windows;

whether Alchemist and Spirit Walker are comparably strong across conventional and Ritual-focused decks;

whether the combined number of Graveyard decisions remains manageable in physical play;

whether player-facing text remains legible at standard card size.

Source authority

This Markdown guide is the definitive Mystics source for v0.6 development. The adjacent DOCX and PDF are release-formatted editions. If an earlier Mystics rule, card text, leader description, or package note conflicts with this guide, this guide governs until superseded by canonical v0.6 data or a later approved revision.